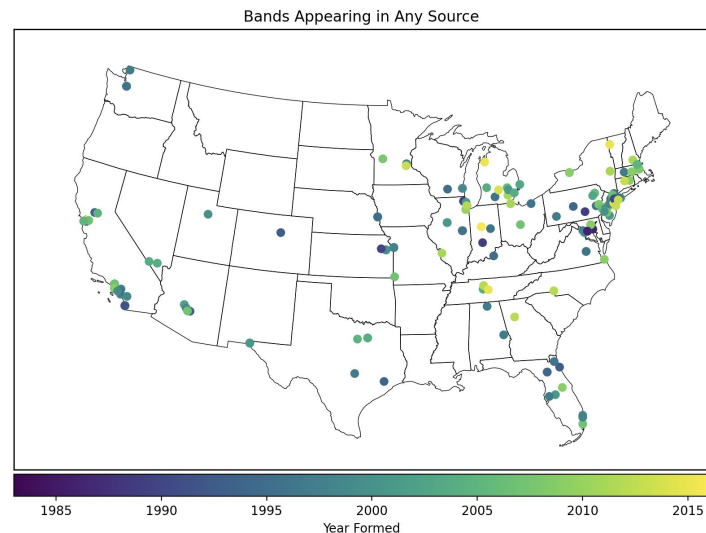


Seeing Is Believing: Graphical Representations of Emo Music in the US

Braden Allmond
Kansas State University

April, 2026

- Objectives
- Initial Idea
- Tools and Methodology
- Data Sources
- Maps and Plots
- Combinations
- Numerical Results
- Conclusions



Objectives

I wanted to do two things

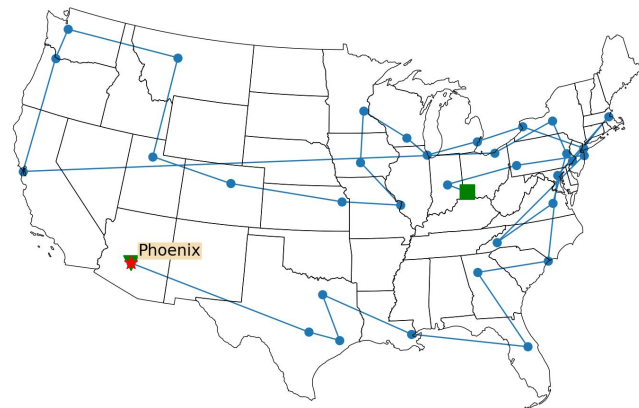
- Make sick plots
- Survey, compile, and compare existing data about emo bands

I am *NOT*

- Prescribing a definition for “emo”
- Saying any source is “more right” than another

Joyce Manor Tour Locations 2026

Mar 9

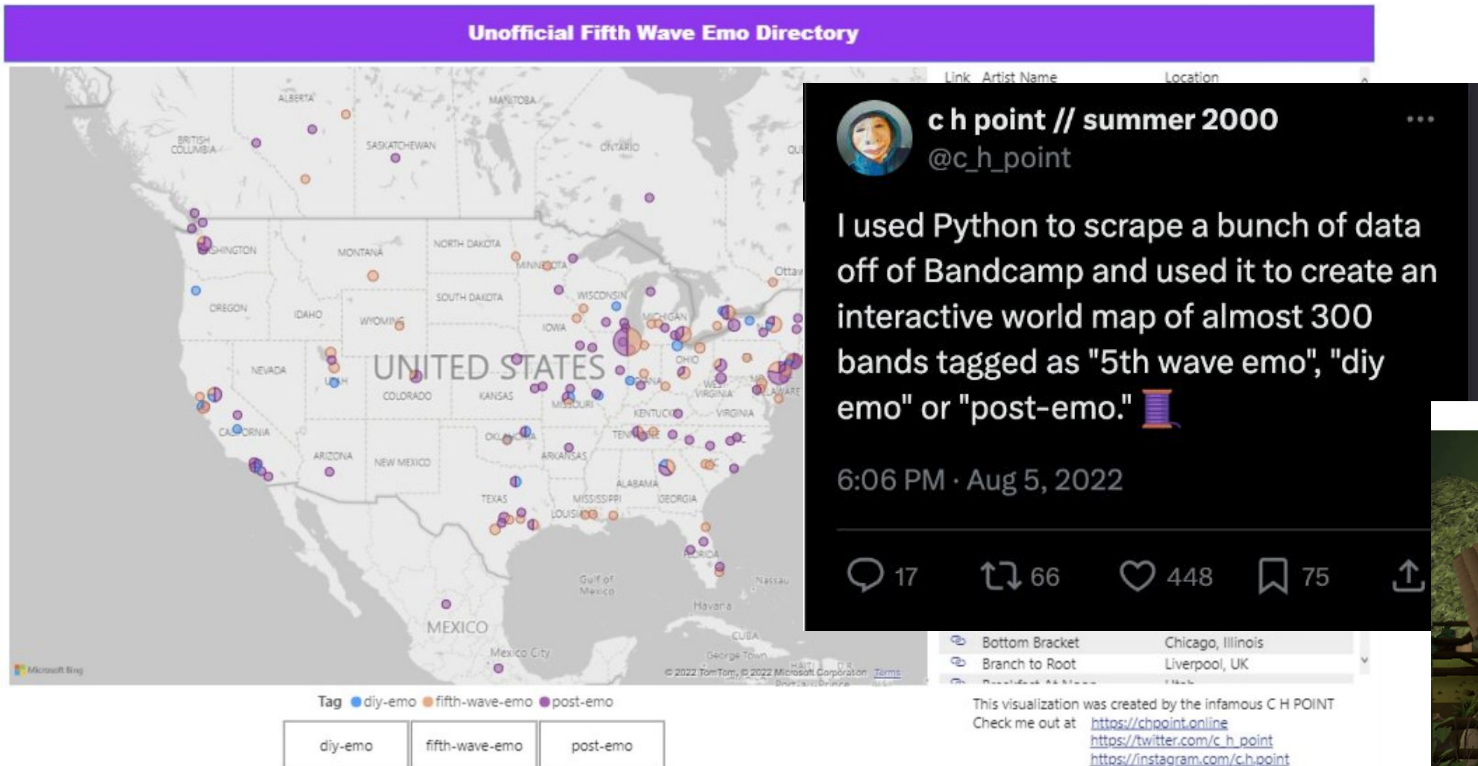


Is this band emo?

Band Name

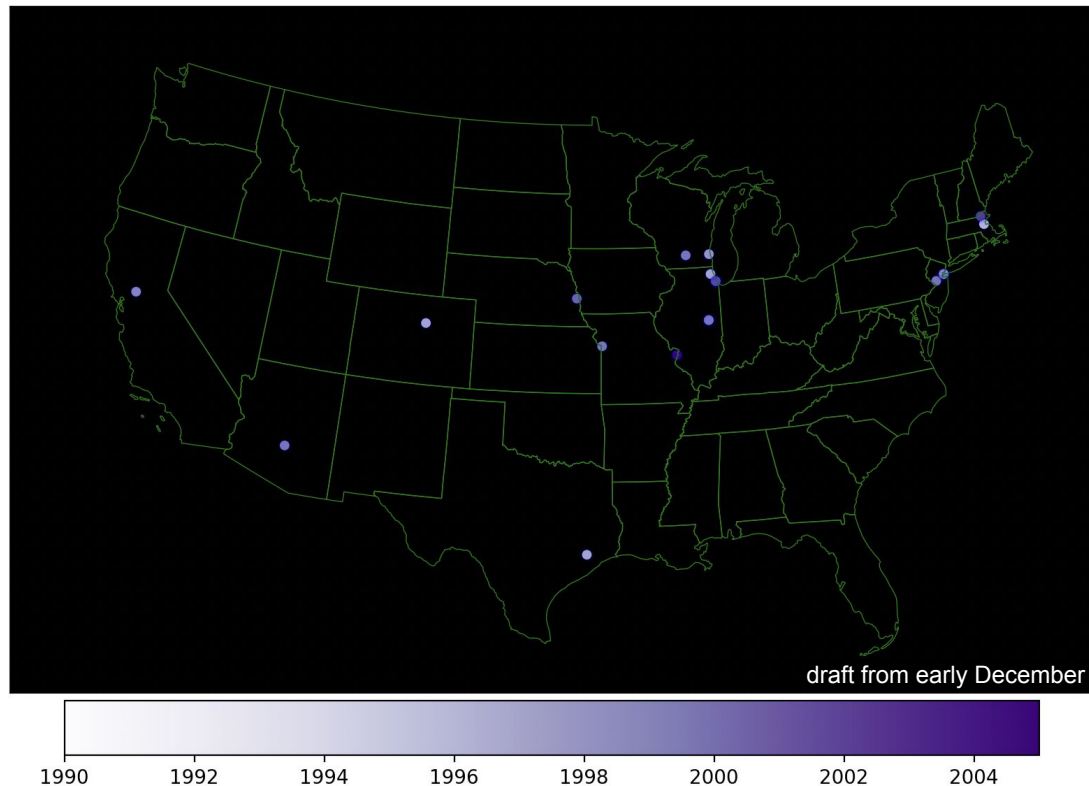
Find Out

Initial Idea : Saw this post on twitter from Summer2000 (c h point)



Initial Idea : First Attempt

Bands Featured on "Anthology of Emo" Cover
by Year of Most Popular Work



I wanted to see if the bands on the cover of Tom Mullen's *Anthology of Emo: I & II* were predominantly from "The Midwest™"

Answer: sort of? But the selection is only one (very informed) guy's opinion.

This was also a creative coding outlet from work. Believe it or not, emo bands are harder to categorize than fundamental particles.

Python

- basemap - interface to anything Geographic Information Systems related, i.e. maps
- matplotlib - de facto standard plotting library for python
- pandas - reading, writing, and editing .csv files as “dataframes”
- numpy - fast numerical recipes

Piecing these together, I can easily transform spreadsheets into maps (and you can too!)



link to github [code](#)

Given the difficulty with interpretation, I thought that more data would lead to a more concrete conclusion (it did not).

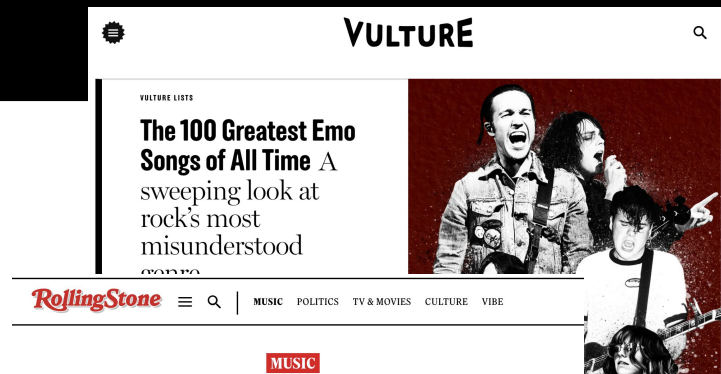
1. Identify reputable compilations of bands, songs, or albums that are called “emo”
 - a. notable individual journalists, long-running magazines, acclaimed books
2. Transform into a spreadsheet
 - a. parsing a webpage, compiling band origin info from Wikipedia, Discogs, sophiesfloorboard, etc.
3. Convert spreadsheet into dataframe for computations and plotting

Some lessons learned:

- scraping data from websites is way easier than I thought it would be
- scraping data from print sources is more time-intensive than I thought it would be

Data Sources

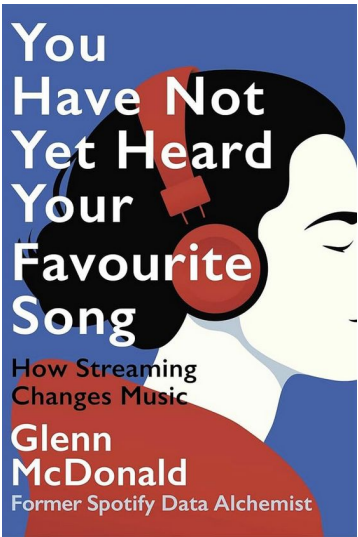
- Comparing 5 sources with differing formats and aims
 - **Washed Up Emo** (Tom Mullen): *Anthology of Emo I & II*
 - **Vulture**: *100 Greatest Emo Songs of All Time*
 - **Rolling Stone**: *40 Greatest Emo Albums of All Time*
 - **Alternative Press**: *The Ultimate Guide to Emo, Past, Present, and Future*
 - **Every Noise at Once** (Glenn McDonald): Emo listing
-
- 4/5 are traditional music journalism formats, digital listicle, magazine article, interview transcripts
-
- ENAO is an odd one out, but still useful



[illegible]

“Every Noise at Once is an inexorably expanding universe of music-processing experiments, starting with a dynamic attempt at a map of all the major genres of music in the world.” — Glenn McDonald

ENAO differs from other sources, not traditional journalism



Dataset Sources Summary

We treat each source as its own dataset, and summarize some of its properties.

Source	Bands	Year Published	Type	Unique Items
Anthology	22	2020	Transcribed Interviews	1
Vulture	95	2020	Digital Listicle	22
RStone	38	2019	Digital Listicle	0
AltPress	74	2017	Magazine	28
ENAO	169	2023	Spotify Map	92

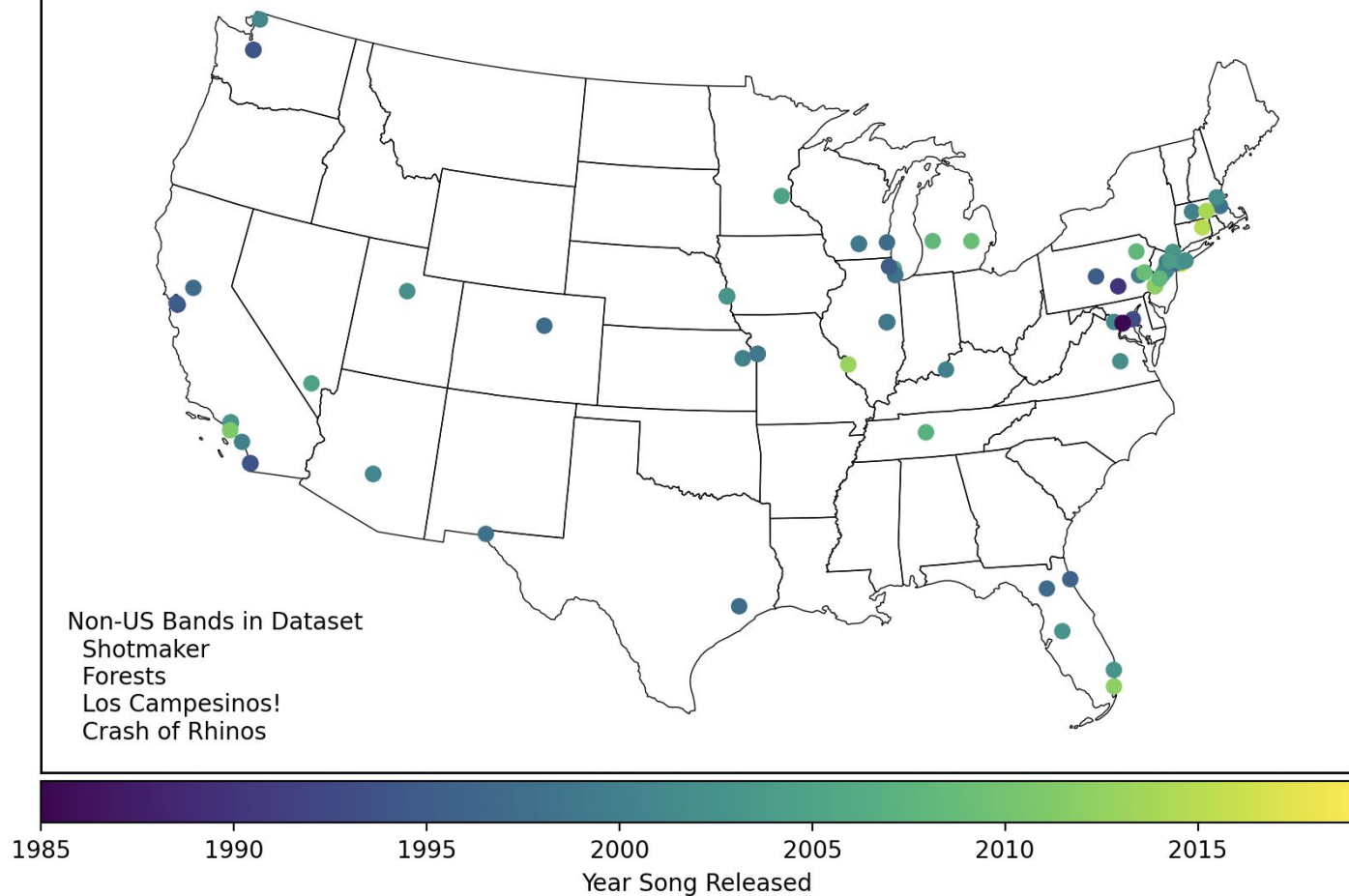
Sources with fewer items are likely to have fewer unique items.

Note that ENAO has the most entries, and the most unique items. Likely because it is not a traditional journalistic collection.



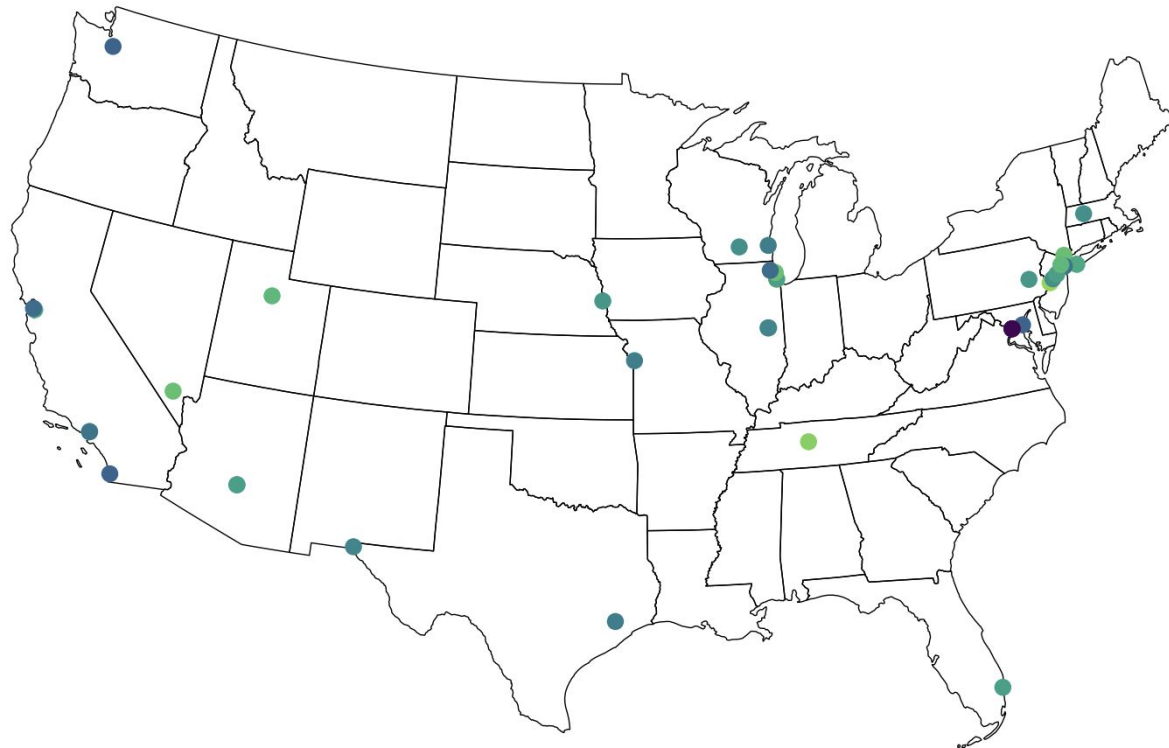
Bands Featured on Vulture's "100 Greatest Emo Songs of All Time"

> 1 Band: New York City:3, Philadelphia:3, Omaha:2, Seattle:2, Los Angeles:3, San Diego:3, Washington D.C.:8,
 > 1 Singles: Rainer Maria:2, Taking Back Sunday:2, Sunny Day Real Estate:2, Jimmy Eat World:2, My Chemical Romance:2,



Bands Featured on Rolling Stone's "40 Greatest Emo Albums of All Time"

> 1 Band: Los Angeles:2, Washington D.C.:2,
> 1 Albums: Jimmy Eat World:2, Brand New:2,



1985

1990

1995

2000

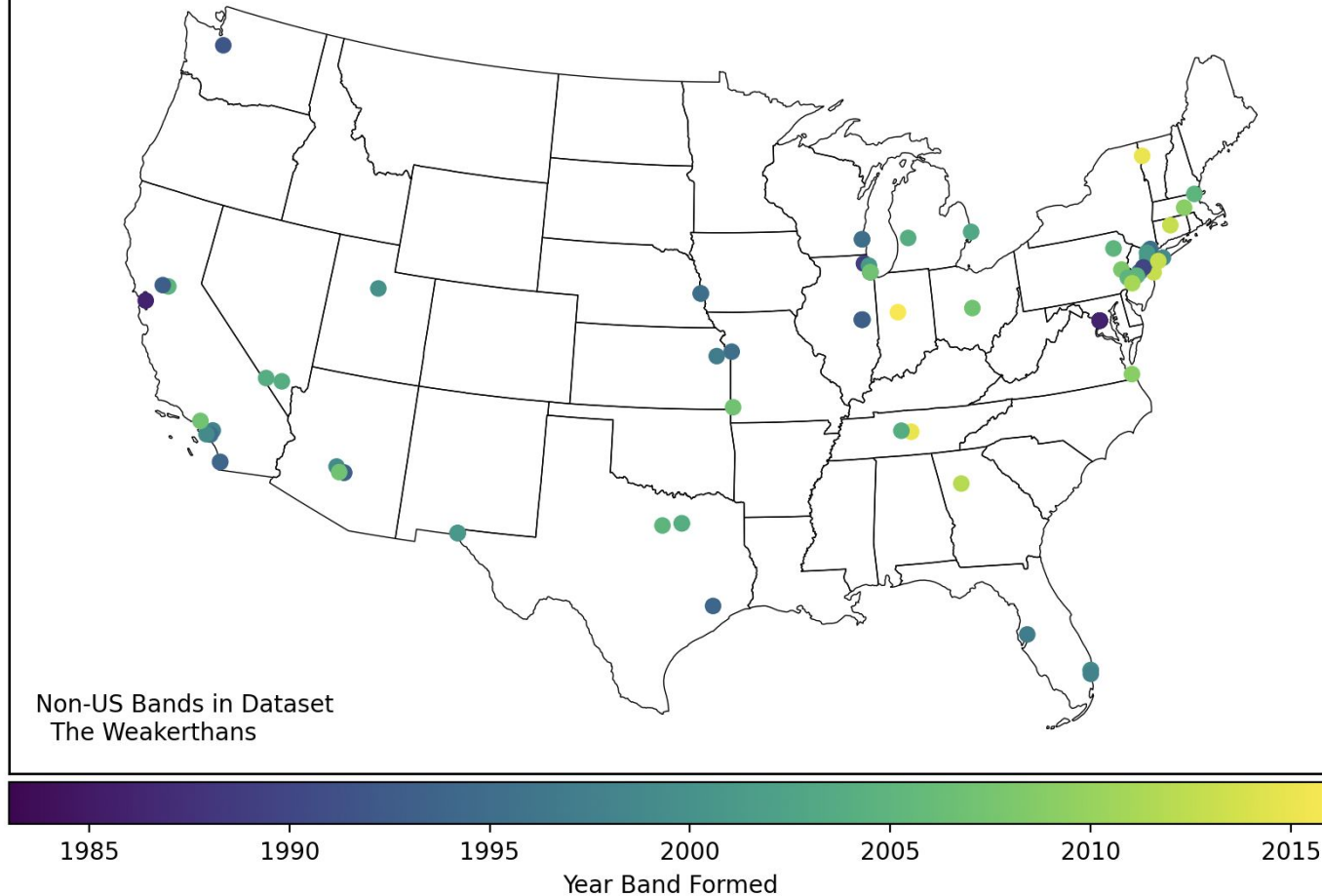
2005

2010

Year Album Released

Bands Referenced in Alternative Press' "Ultimate Guide to Emo"

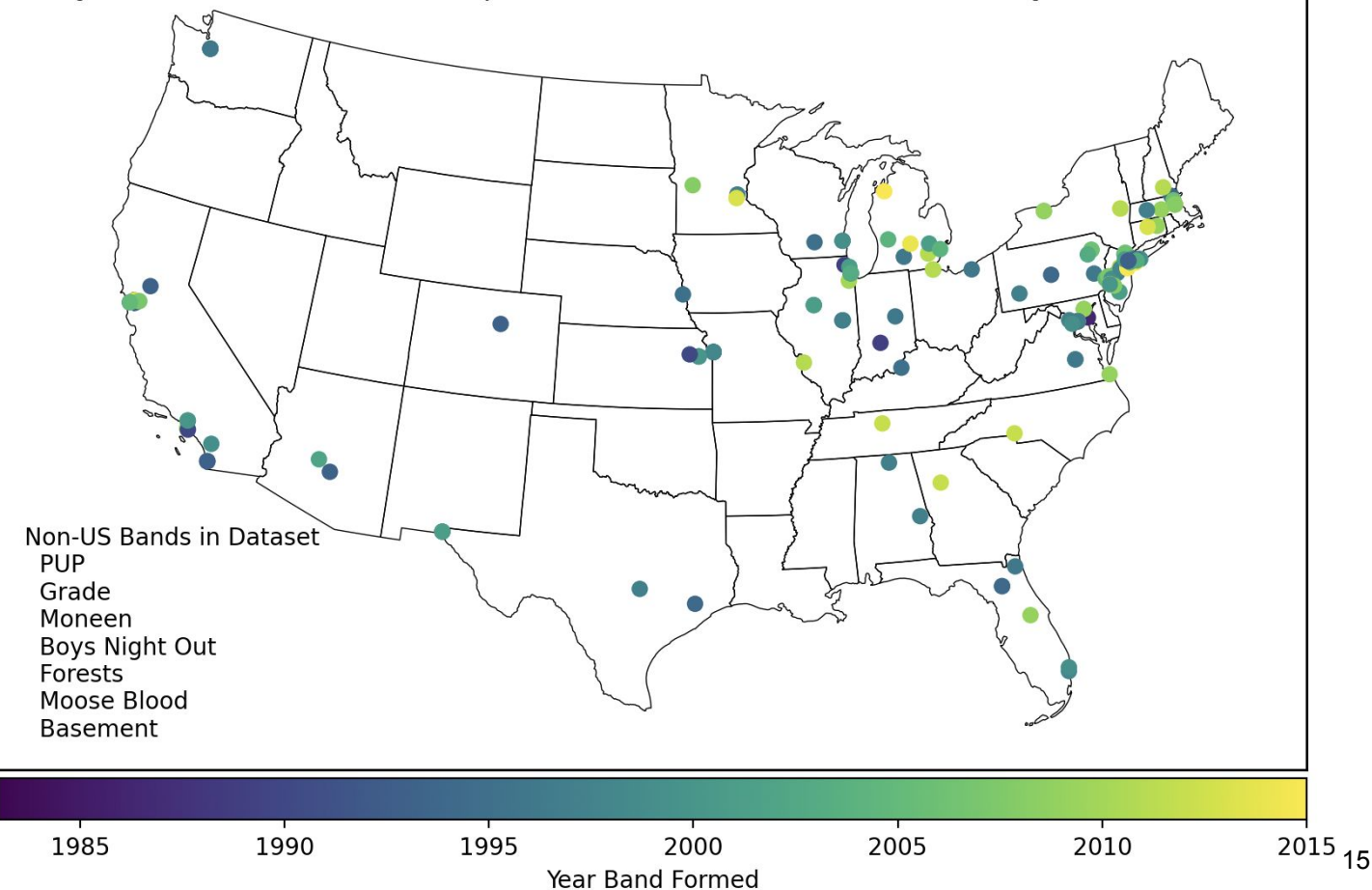
> 1 Band: Chicago:2, Washington D.C.:3,



Maps: Every Noise at Once

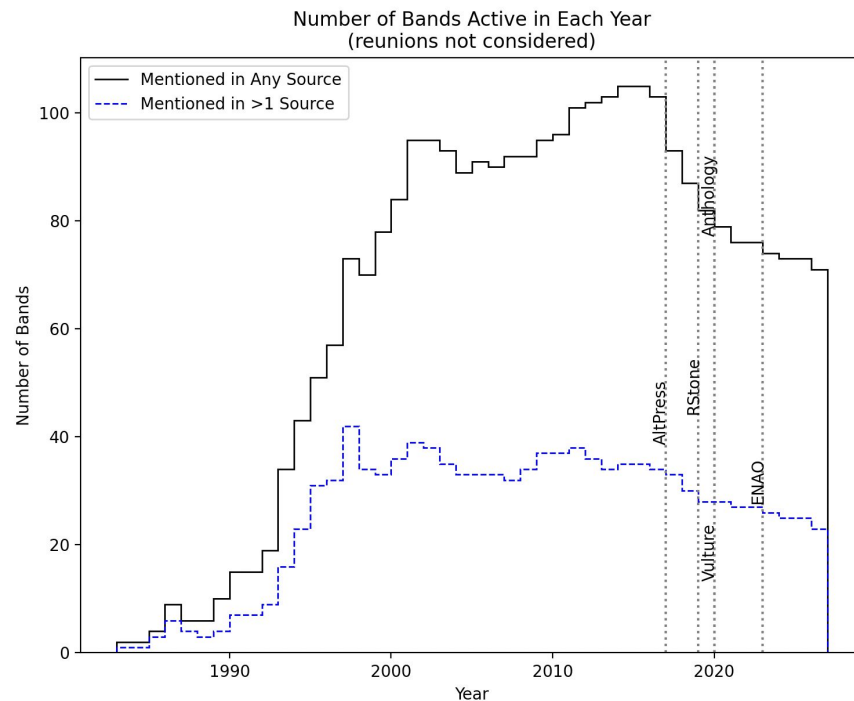
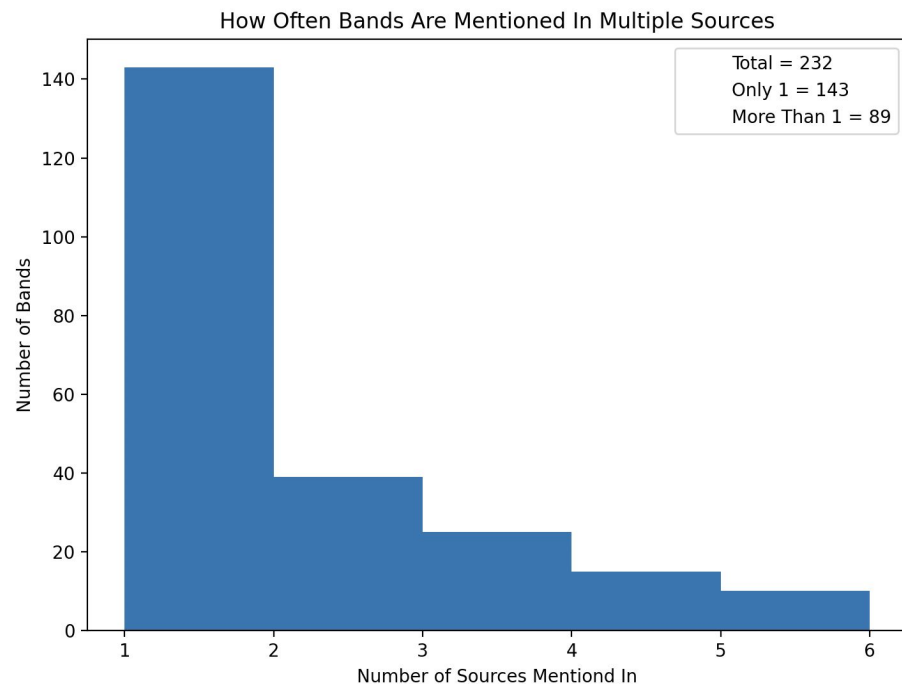
Bands Included in Glenn McDonald's "Every Noise at Once" Emo Genre Listing

> 1 Band: Los Angeles:3, Bloomington:2, Long Island:2, Boston:5, Chicago:9, Gainesville:2, Albany:2, Kansas City:4, Baltimore:2, Milwaukee:2, Seattle:4, Brooklyn:3, Peoria:3, Torrance:2, Toledo:2, El Paso:2, Berkeley:2, Philadelphia:8, San Diego:4, New Brunswick:3, Richmond:2, New York City:5, Lawrence:3, Scranton:2, San Francisco:2, Rochester:2, Washington D.C.:8,



Combining Sources

We can combine sources, and take the number of times a band is mentioned across all sources as a shared indicator of its relevance to the genre.

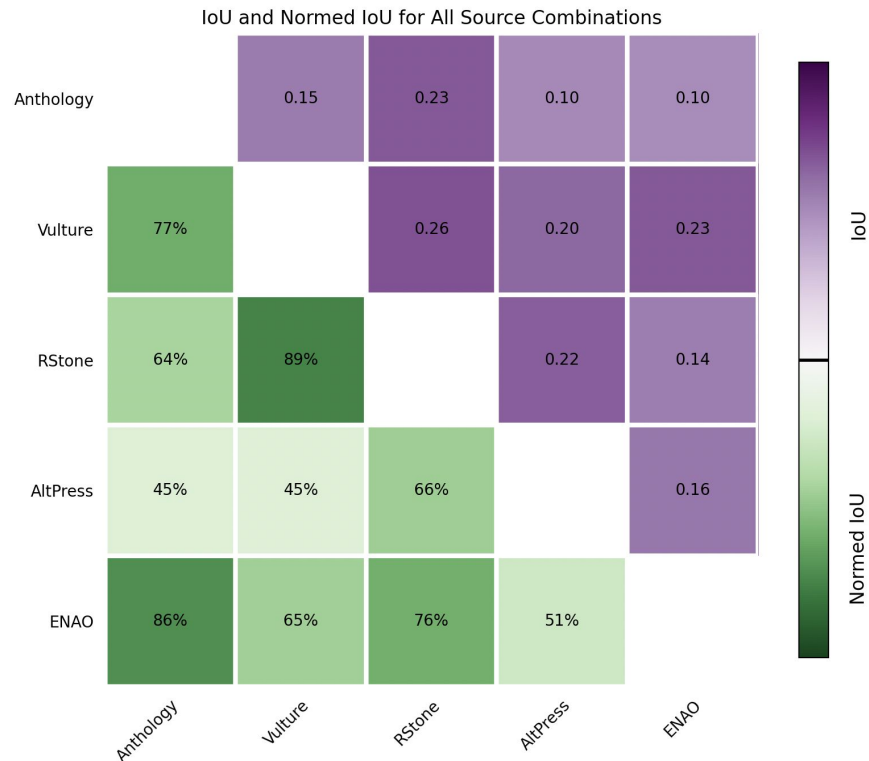
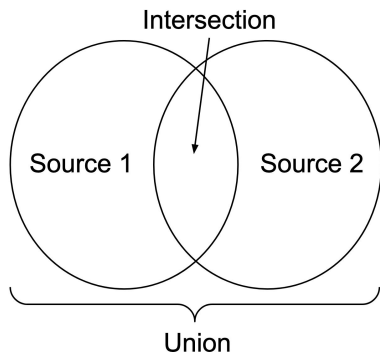


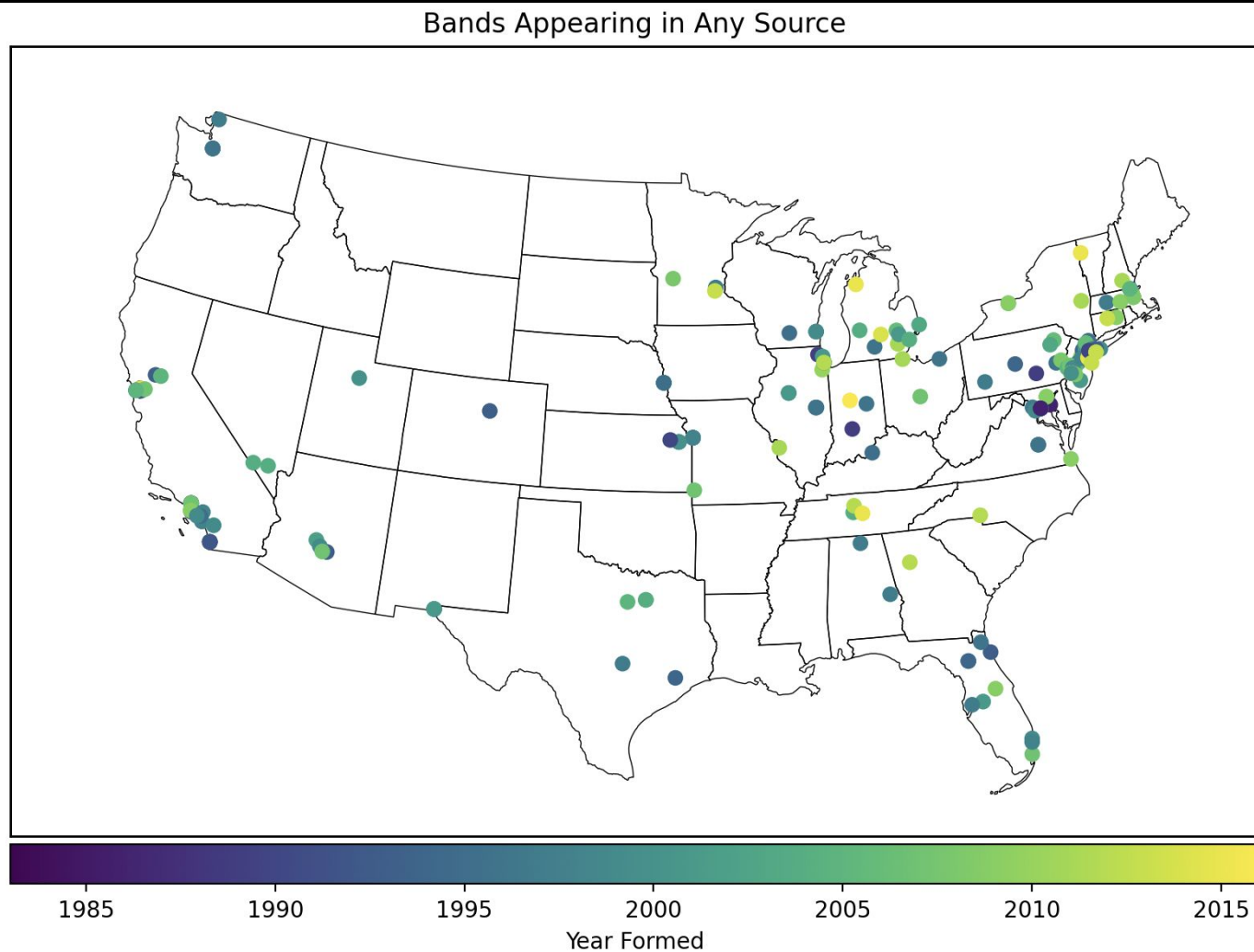
Combinations

Ask someone to list emo bands, and you get an idea of what they think emo is.

If you ask two people, and they make identical lists, they probably think about emo similarly.

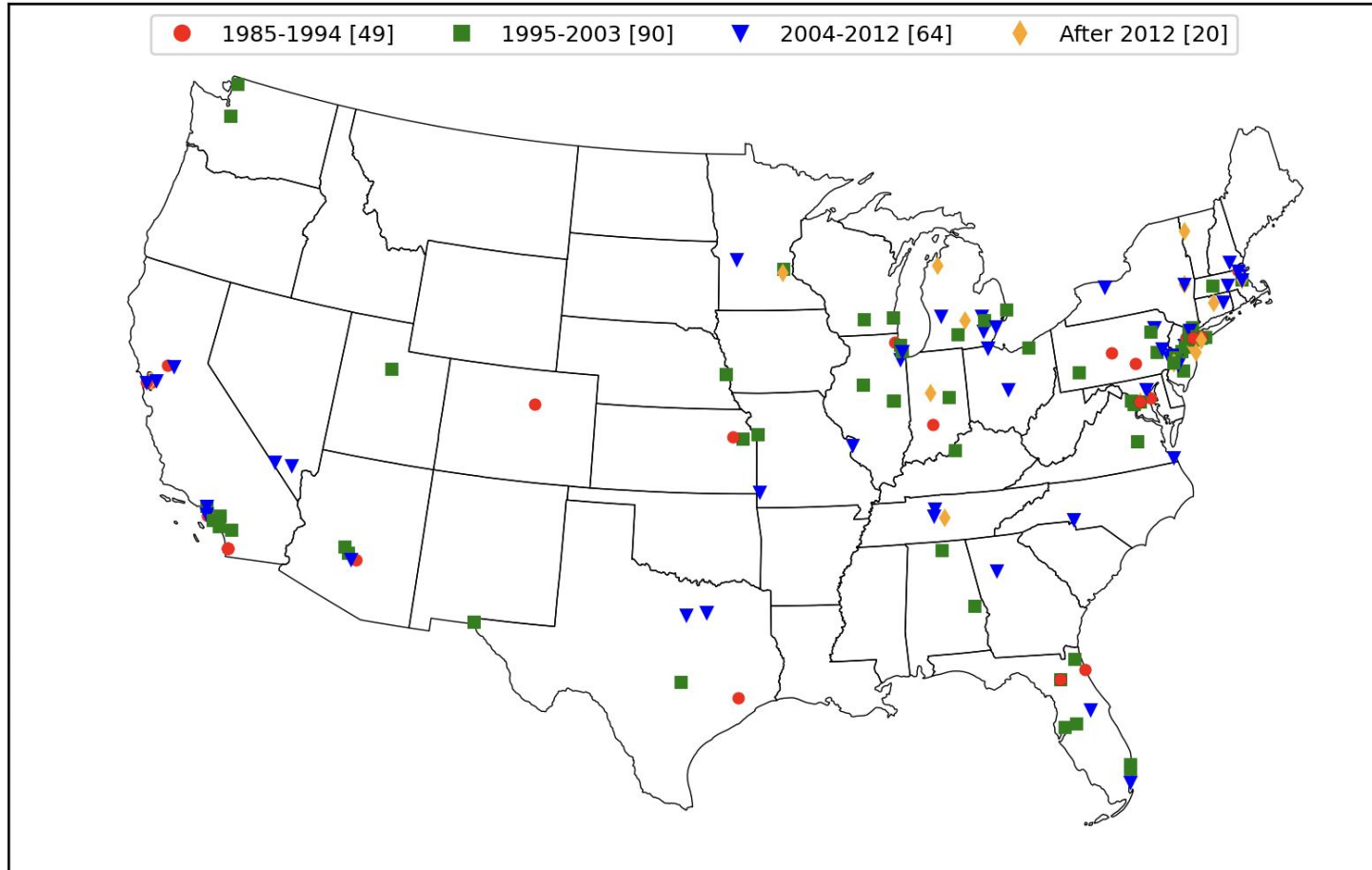
This metric is *intersection over union* (IoU), the ratio of bands in common between two sources to the total number of bands combined. If we *normalize* by the maximum possible value in common for a given comparison, then we have what percentage of the smaller dataset is found in the larger dataset.





Categorized by Formation Year, Any Source

Bands Appearing in Any Source, Categorized by Year Formed



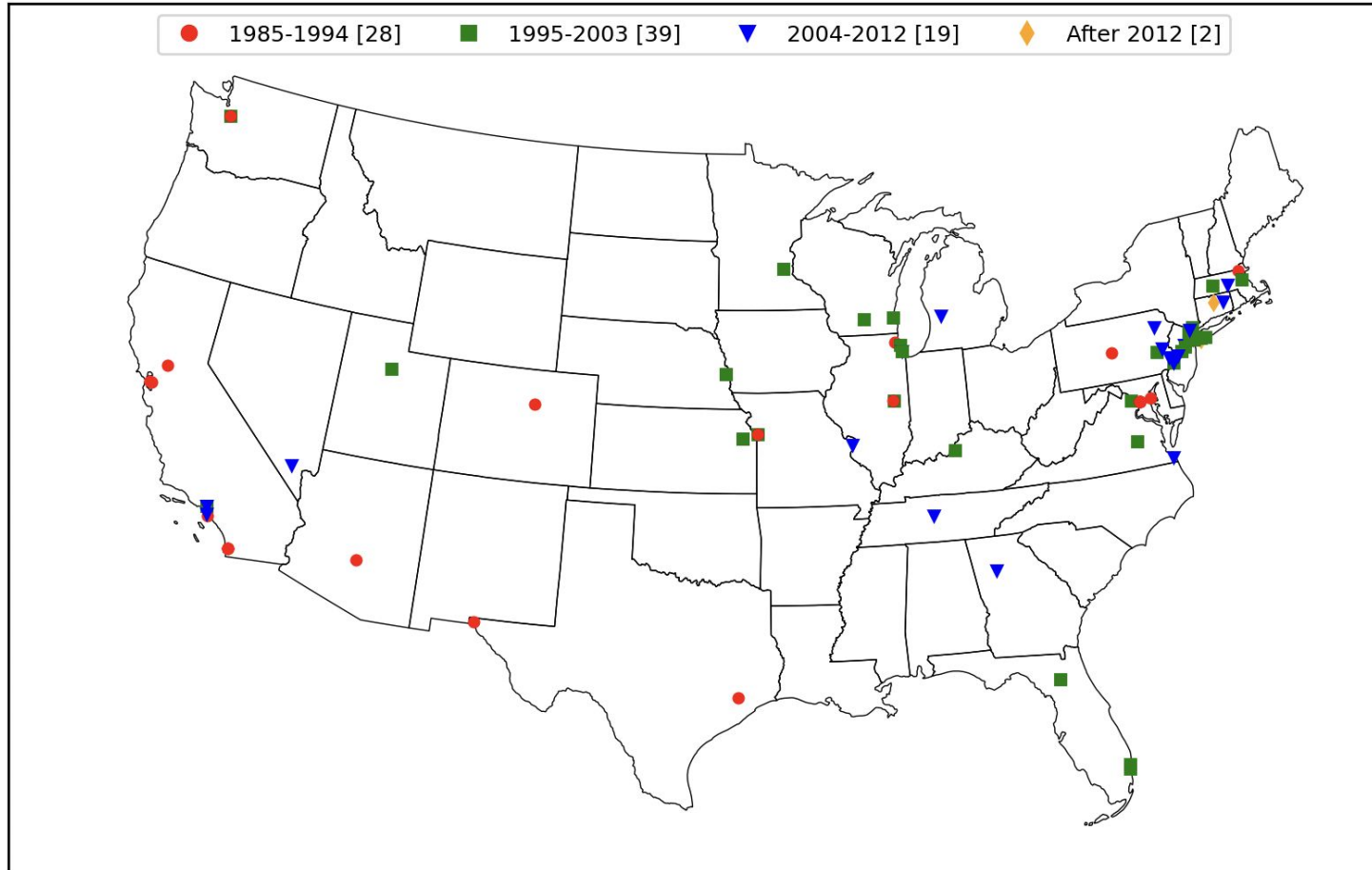
Categorized by Formation Year

AND required to be in at least two sources.

Year cutoffs are roughly equidistant.

Changing 2003 to 2001 only changes the categorization of 1 point on the east coast.

Bands Appearing in 2 or More Sources, Categorized by Year Formed



Conclusions

- Sources surveyed have consensus at a minimum of 45%, often greater
- Visually pleasing plots, but interpretation requires care
 - what was originally meant by “midwest emo”?
 - was it a handful of influential bands from a large region, OR an explosion of DIY activity in smaller cities, OR a secret third thing?
- Plotting program suitable for use by anyone familiar with python
 - mapped region is customizable, but most emo bands are from the US
 - compatible with any year+location data in a csv file
- Numerous additional sources to include: Andy Greenwald’s *Nothing Feels Good*, Chris Payne’s *Where Are Your Boys Tonight*, Dan Ozzi’s *Sellout*, Tom Mullen’s *Is This Band Emo?*, etc.

Thanks! Questions?



References

Mullen, Tom. *Anthology of Emo Volumes I and II*, Washed Up Books, 2020.

Cohen, Ian, David Anthony, Nina Corcoran, Emma Garland, and Brad Nelson. “The 100 Greatest Emo Songs of All Time A sweeping look at rock’s most misunderstood genre.” *Vulture*, Feb. 13, 2020, <https://www.vulture.com/article/best-emo-songs.html>

Bayer, Jonah, Aaron Burgess, Suzy Exposito, Leor Galil, James Montgomery, and Brittany Spanos. “40 Greatest Emo Albums of All Time”, *RollingStone*, September 4, 2019, <https://www.rollingstone.com/music/music-lists/40-greatest-emo-albums-of-all-time-23526/>

Richman, Jesse, Trevor Kelley, Evan Lucy, Anthony Pappalardo, Brian Shultz, and Cassie Whitt. *The Ultimate Guide to Emo: Past, Present, and Future*, Alternative Press, no. 352, November 2017, Alternative Press Magazine Inc., Cleveland, Ohio, ISSN 1065 1667

McDonald, Glenn. *Every Noise at Once: Emo Map*, November 2023, <https://everynoise.com/research.cgi?mode=genre&name=emo>

Literally over 200 wikipedia, discogs, or sophies floorboard pages (see next slide for links)

Datasets

“Emocon 2026 Dataset” (all datasets combined)

- <https://datawrapper.dwcdn.net/VVp4/1/>

Individual sheets (you can derive these from the master sheet, but are here for convenience)

- Anthology: <https://datawrapper.dwcdn.net/Ohl2b/1/>
- Vulture: <https://datawrapper.dwcdn.net/mh9zh/1/>
- Rolling Stone: <https://datawrapper.dwcdn.net/3Ngy9/1/>
- Alternative Press: <https://datawrapper.dwcdn.net/2ZWUY/1/>
- ENAO: <https://datawrapper.dwcdn.net/nOQan/1/>

Let me know if there are any issues with links!

I assume bands mentioned in most sources are the most relevant to the genre, and share them here.

Bands appearing in 4 sources: 15

Texas Is The Reason, Rainer Maria, Knapsack, The Jealous Sound, Cursive, At the Drive-In, Embrace, My Chemical Romance, Thursday, Texas Is the Reason, Fall Out Boy, Taking Back Sunday, Sunny Day Real Estate, Rites of Spring, Jawbreaker

Bands appearing in all sources: 9

The Promise Ring, Dashboard Confessional, Cap'n Jazz, American Football, The Get Up Kids, Mineral, Jimmy Eat World, Braid, Saves the Day

Non-US bands in the combined dataset: 9

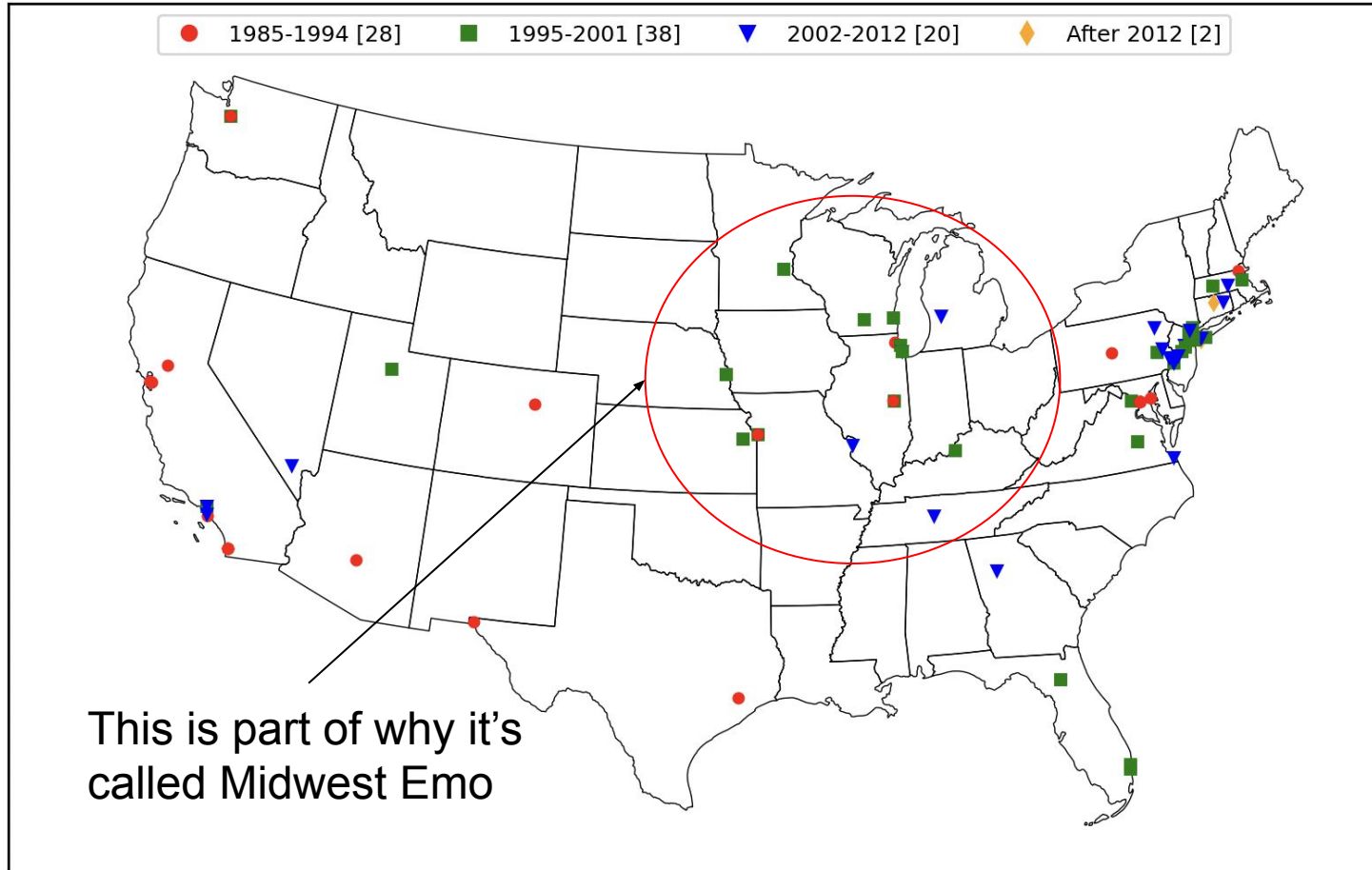
Shotmaker, PUP, Grade, Moneen, Boys Night Out, The Weakerthans, Forests, Los Campesinos!, Crash of Rhinos

Categorized by Formation Year

AND required to be
in at least TWO
sources.

Updated cutoff is
2003 -> 2001

Bands Appearing in 2 or More Sources, Categorized by Year Formed

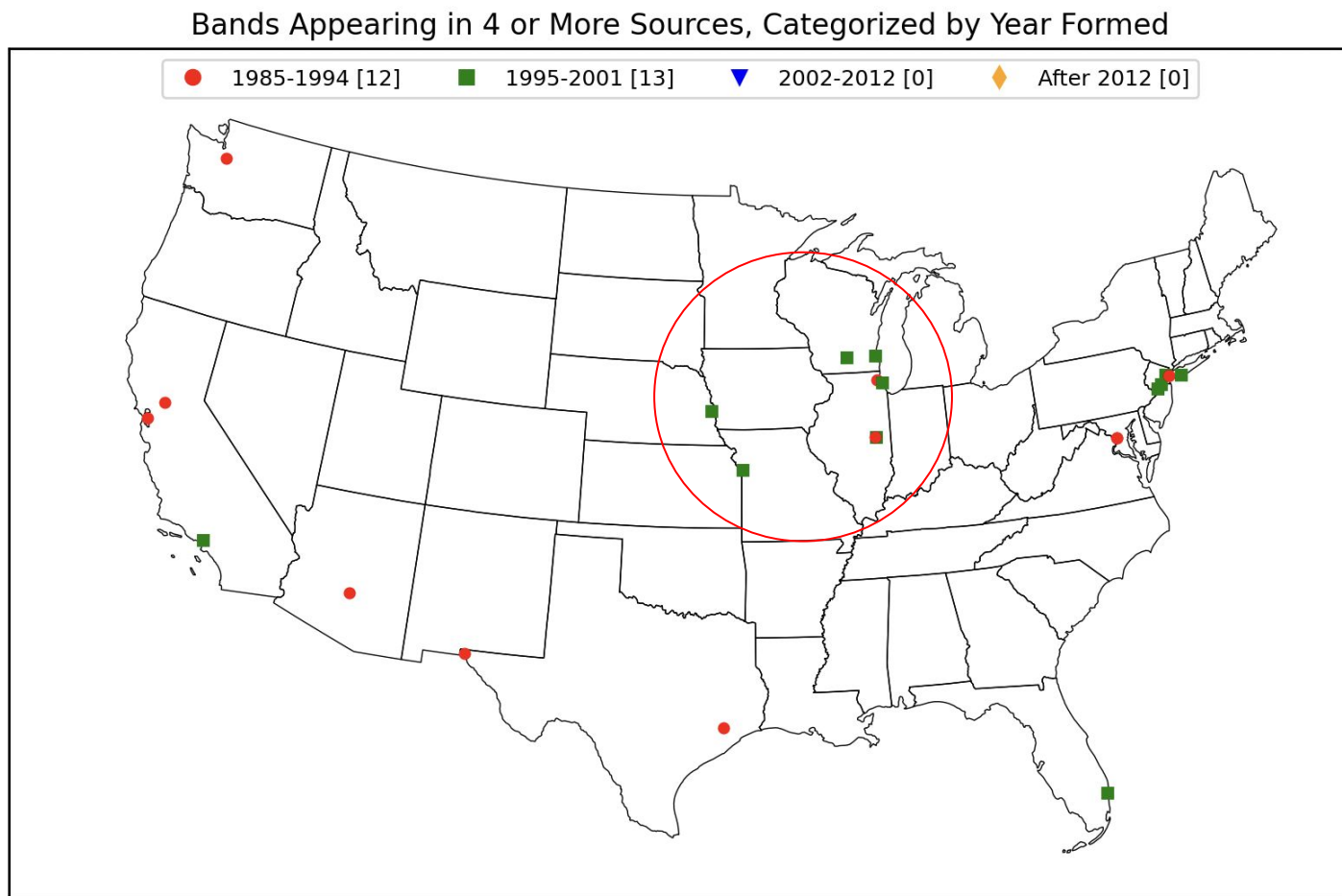


Categorization by Formation Year

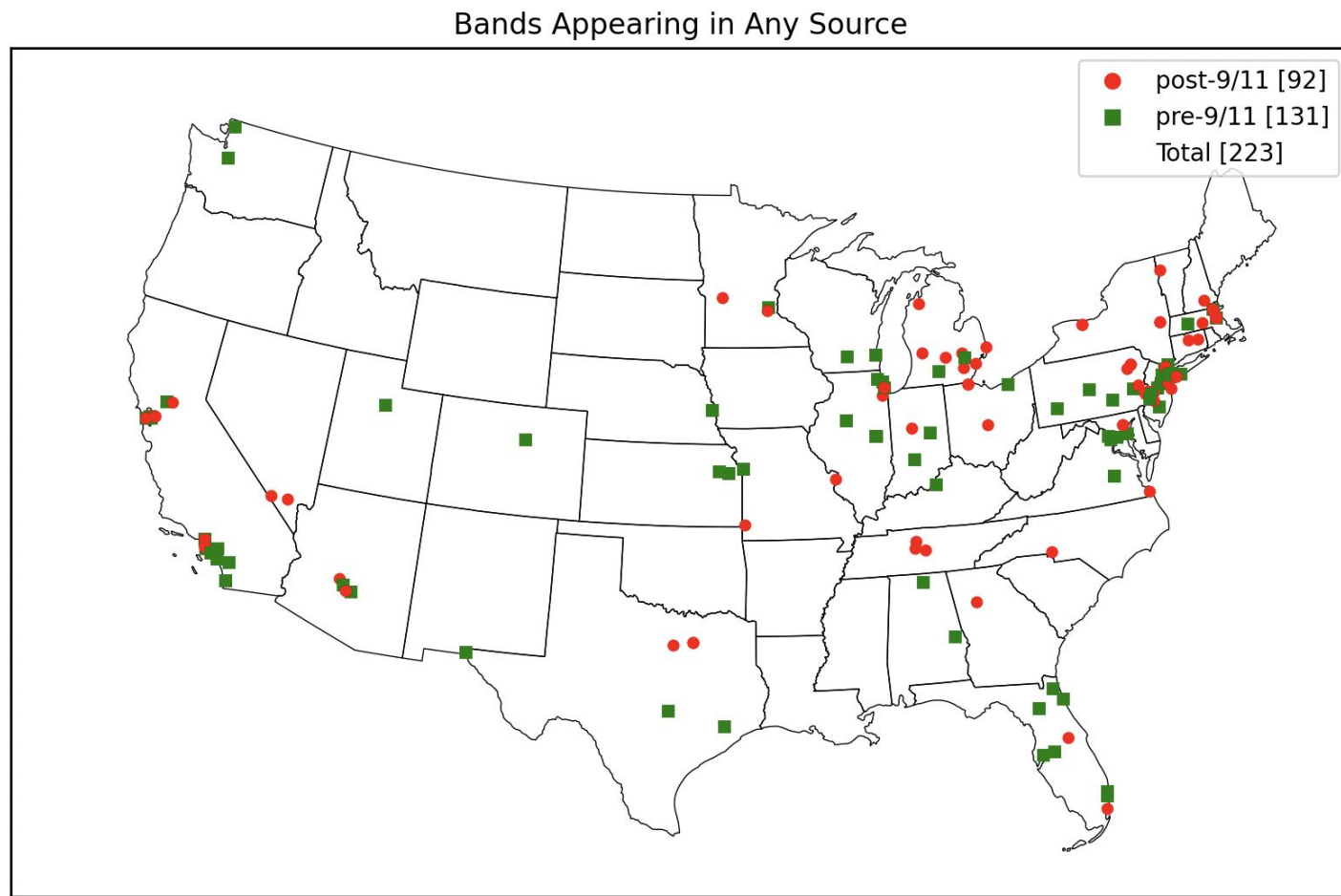
AND required to be in at least FOUR sources.

As more sources are required, only the most notable points remain.

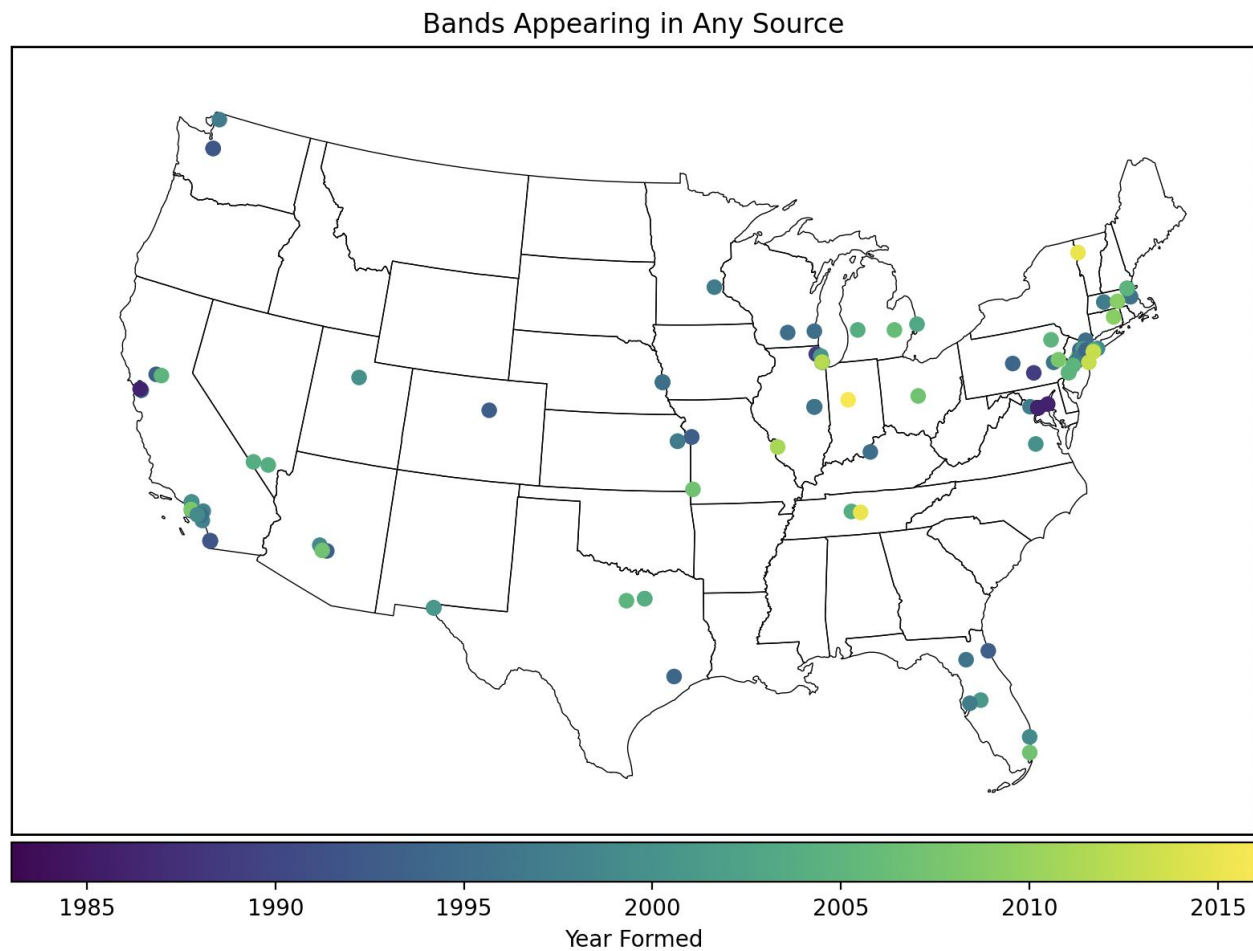
We can see a cluster on the East Coast, and in The Midwest



Maps: All Sources Split by Formation before and after 2001

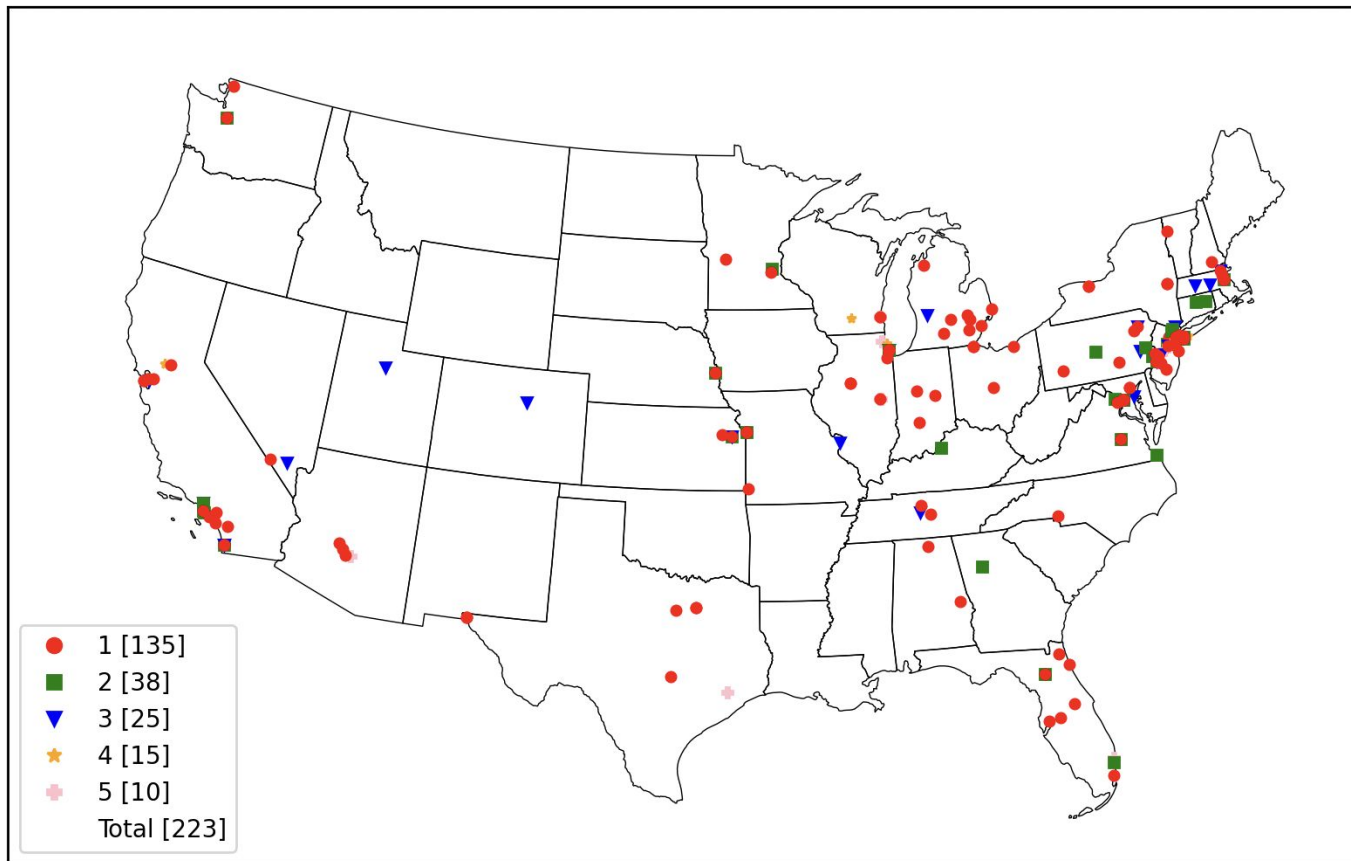


Maps: All Sources Except ENAO

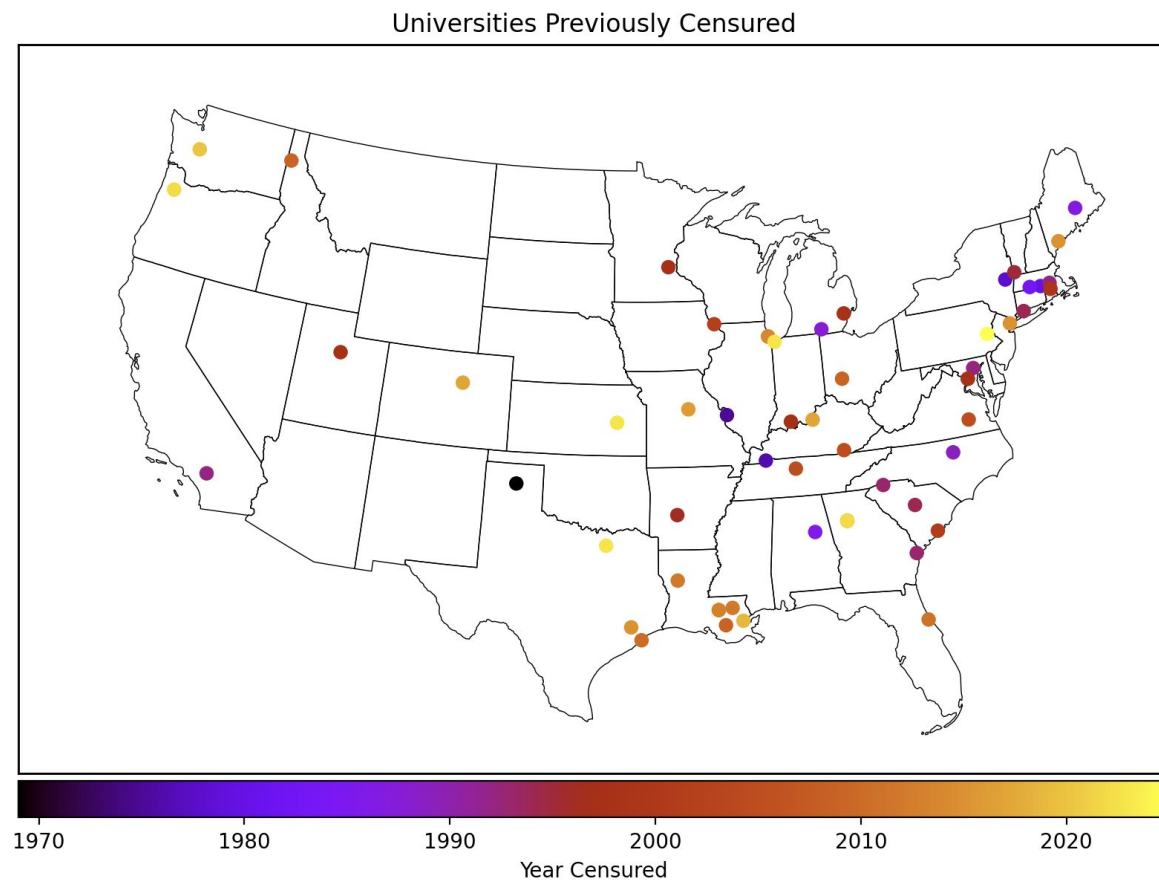


Maps: All Sources Categorized by Number of Times Appearing in Sources

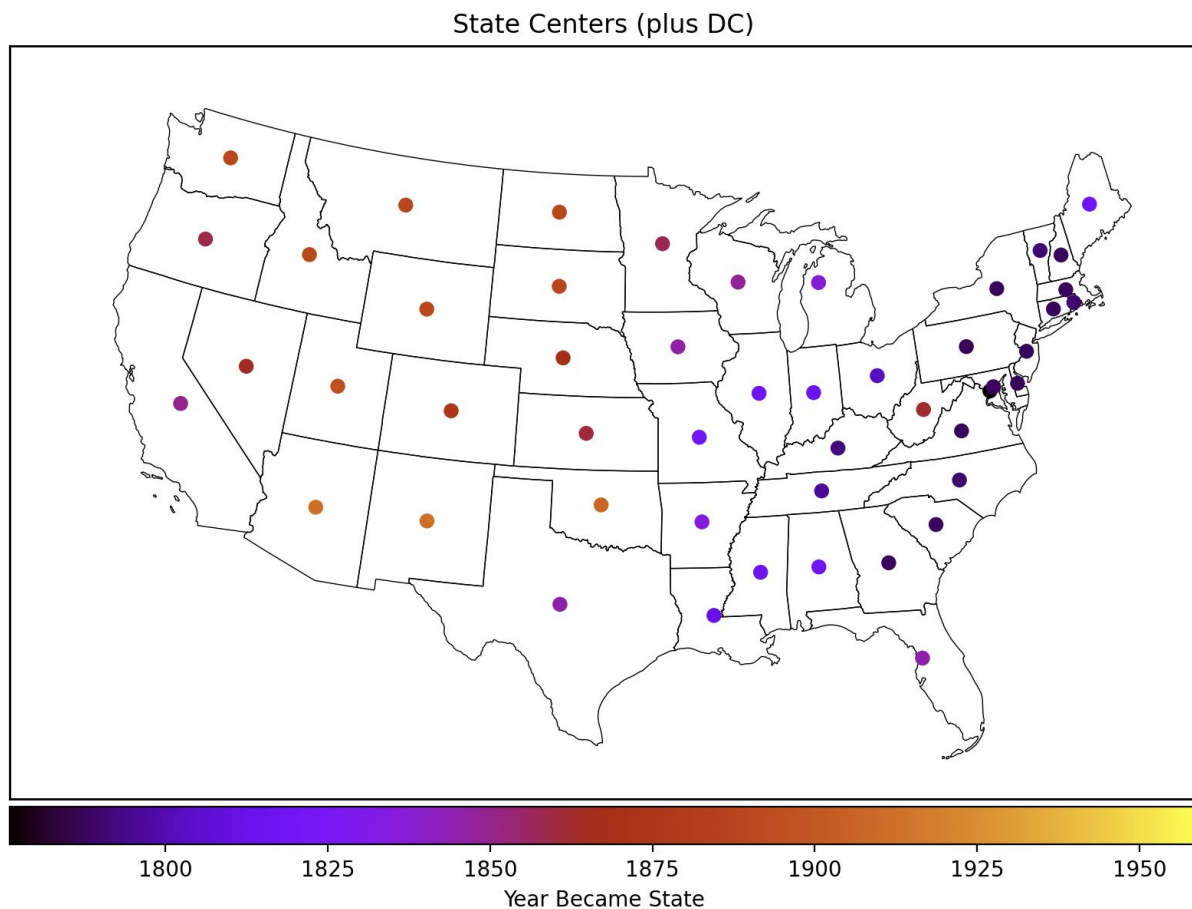
In x sources coloring



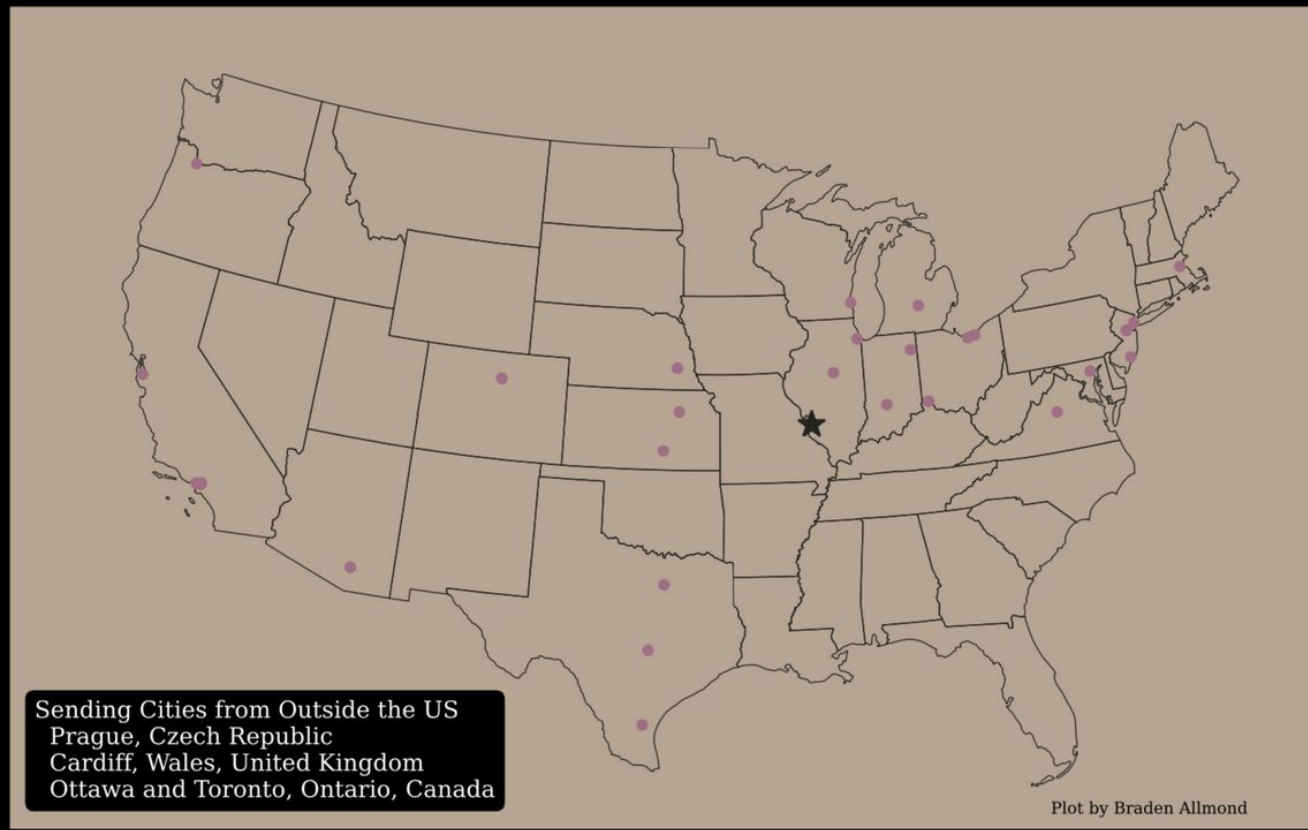
Other Uses: Universities Censured by AAUP



Other Uses: Year States Joined the United States



Emocon Speakers By Location



shouts out
Taylor
Grimes for
additional
styling!

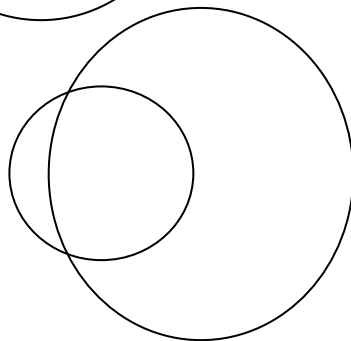
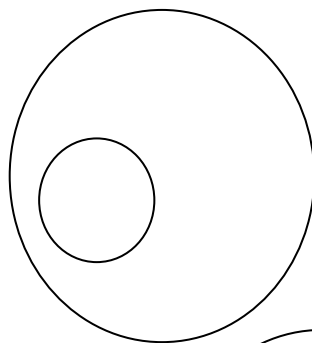
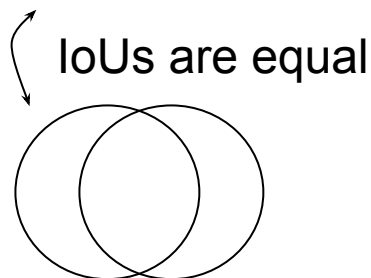
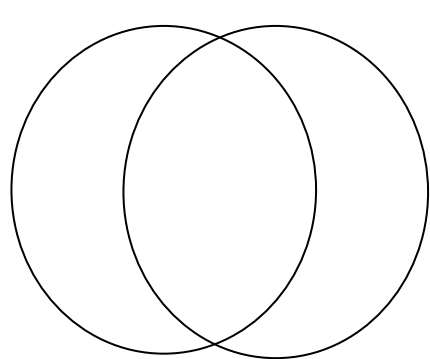
Dataset Summary with IoU Values

Source	Items	Year Published	Type	Unique Items	IoU to Combined*	Normed IoU
Anthology	22	2020	Transcribed Interviews	1	0.083	96%
Vulture	95	2020	Digital Listicle	22	0.239	77%
RStone	38	2019	Digital Listicle	0	0.141	100%
AltPress	74	2017	Magazine	28	0.165	62%
ENAO	169	2023	Spotify Map	92	0.249	55%

Here, IoU is calculated by comparing an individual dataset to the other four datasets combined. The normed IoU is also reported. The values indicate each individual source has better than 50% agreement with multiple sources combined, though individual source to individual source agreement is lower.

Aside on IoU

- IoU depends on dataset size
- Larger datasets have larger unions
- Smaller datasets (almost) necessarily have larger intersections with larger datasets



$\text{IoU} \neq 1!$

Union and Intersection Counts for All Source Combinations

	Anthology	Vulture	RStone	AltPress	ENAO
Anthology		100	46	86	172
Vulture	17		99	136	202
RStone	14	34		87	178
AltPress	10	33	25		205
ENAO	19	62	29	38	

Union and Intersection labels are placed on the diagonal line of the table.

Interpretation of IoU depends on the size of the datasets. So, normalize by maximum IoU to get consistent interpretation.

Venn Diagram

